

The harbor woke slowly under a thin coastal fog, and the fishing boats nudged against their moorings as the tide began to turn. Gulls wheeled over the breakwater, calling to one another in the gray light while the first dock crews shuffled out with thermoses of coffee.

By mid-morning the fog had burned away and the water turned a hard, bright blue. Tourists drifted along the boardwalk, pausing at the stalls that sold smoked fish and hand-knotted rope, and the smell of salt and frying batter hung over the whole waterfront like a banner.

Old Marten kept his shop at the far end of the pier, where the planks creaked loudest and the rent was cheapest. He had mended nets there for forty years, and he claimed he could read the coming weather in the way the canvas awnings snapped against their frames each dawn.